

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

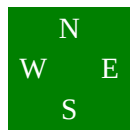
Declarer: East

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ J 9 3 2
♥ K 8 5 4
♦ J 7
♣ A 7 3

♠ A Q 5
♥ A Q 10 3
♦ A K Q
♣ Q 9 4



♠ 10 7 6 4
♥ 7
♦ 9 6 4 2
♣ K J 8 2

♠ K 8
♥ J 9 6 2
♦ 10 8 5 3
♣ 10 6 5

West	North	East	South
	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
game.

You certainly have a Notrump type hand, but you are too strong to open 2NT.

With 23 points you open 2♣. Partner says 2♦.

What is your next bid?

Now you show your 23 point, balanced hand by bidding 2NT. This is not forcing on partner, he might pass.

However, he doesn't pass, he says 3♣.

What is your next bid?

This is no different than a 3♣ bid after an opening 2NT. It is Stayman.

So you bid your 4-card ♥ suit and partner bids the

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣2. The defense takes three ♣ tricks, then plays a small ♦.

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Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 3 : Total = 4

Since you've already lost the 3 ♣ tricks the Goal of your Plan is simple - **Don't Lose the ♥**.

That makes the card assumptions simple also - **West Must Have the ♥K**.

You only have one dummy entry so once you use it you must remain in dummy until you have finished finessing. If West has the ♥K x you can't go wrong. If he has ♥K x x you will have to play with care. And if he has ♥K x x x you must play perfectly.

Enter dummy with the ♠K. Lead the ♥9 and let it ride. Assuming it wins, lead the ♥J and play your ♥10 under it. Now lead a small ♥ and finesse the ♥Q. This way you get all four ♥ tricks. No other way will work.

To prove that only the original ♥9 play will work . . **VISUALIZE:**

(1) That your first play from dummy was ♥J, and you played ♥3 from your hand. The next ♥ would have to be taken in your hand and you no longer have a finesse.

(2) That your first play from dummy was the ♥J and you played ♥10 under it. To stay in dummy one more trick you would have to play the ♥9 and put the ♥3 under it. But when you play the ♥9 West will cover with his ♥K. You can win with the ♥A but are left with ♥Q 3 and the lead will be in your hand. You will lose a trick to West's ♥8 5.

Board 3

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A 8 5 3

♥ 6 2

♦ A 8

♣ A J 10 8 5

♠ Q J 9 2

♥ 10 5 3

♦ J 6 4

♣ Q 9 2



♠ K 4

♥ K J 9

♦ K 10 7 2

♣ K 6 4 3

♠ 10 7 6

♥ A Q 8 7 4

♦ Q 9 5 3

♣ 7

West

1 ♣

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

North

Pass

East

2NT

South

Pass

With 13 points and good 4-card support you are strong enough to jump to 3♣.

However an 11 trick minor game is not as attractive as a 9 trick Notrump game, so you should also consider a jump to 2NT.

Looking at all those Kings should sway you to 2NT. You prefer to be declarer on this hand so the opening lead comes up to one those Kings. Partner bids 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads ♥7, North plays ♥10 and you win ♥J.

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Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 7

The opening lead gave you 1 ♥ trick. If ♣s split 2-2 you can make 10 tricks! But wait, you only need 9 tricks. What if you play 2 top ♣s and it turns out North has ♣ Q x x ? He could win the next ♣ and lead a ♥ through your ♥ K 9. That would not be good.

So North is the Danger hand and he must be kept out of the lead. At trick two cross to dummy with the ♣A. Then play the ♣J, letting it ride if North doesn't cover. If South has the ♣Q you will lose the trick but he cannot play ♥s without setting up your ♥K. You will win 4 ♣ tricks and the game. If North actually does have the ♣Q you will make an overtrick.

EIGHT EVER, NINE NEVER ???.

That old guideline says you should finesse for a missing Queen when you and partner have eight cards in the suit, but play for the drop when you have nine.

All else being equal, it's a good guideline. But sometimes all else **ISN'T** equal, like in this hand where you absolutely must not let North get the lead.